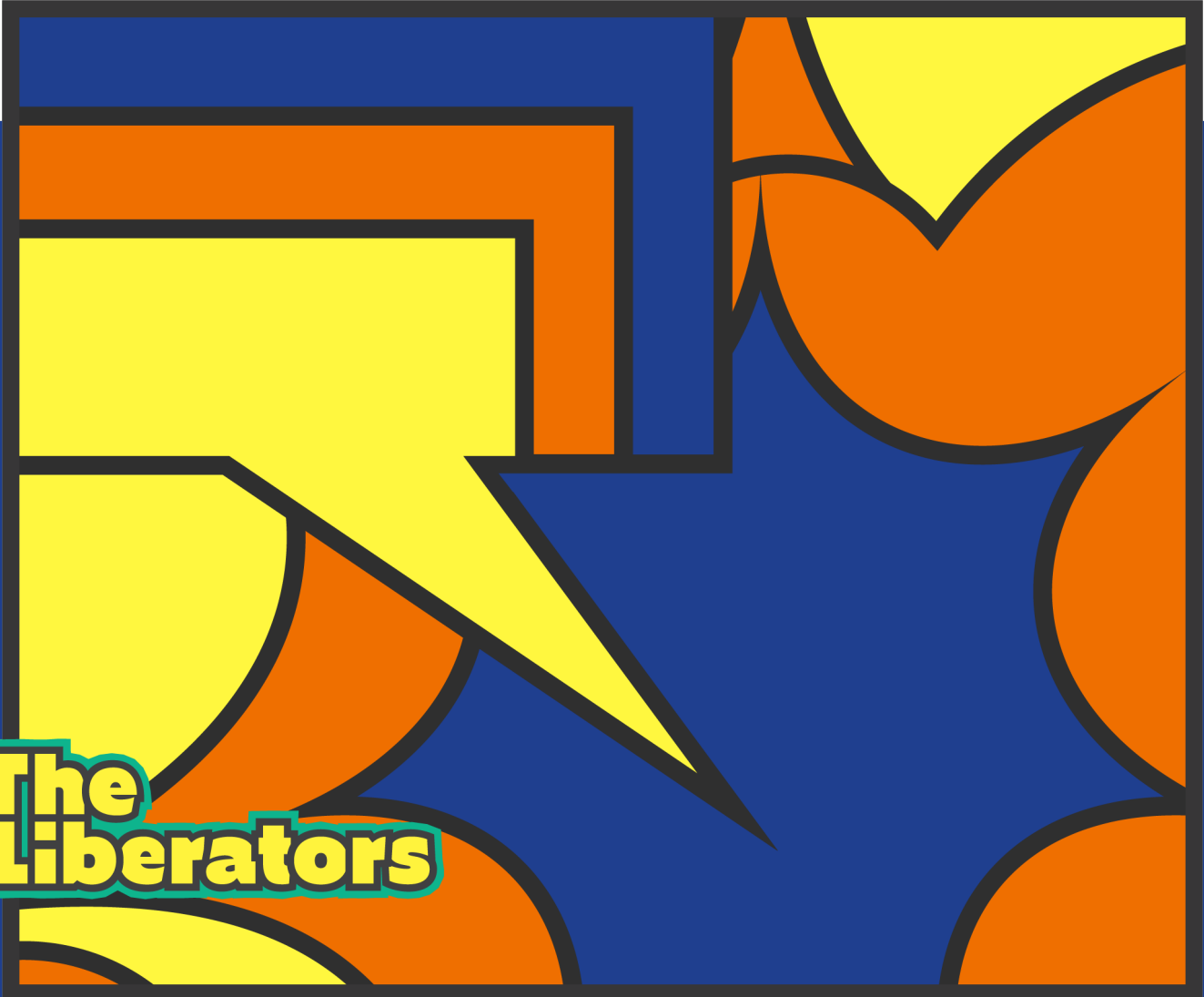


Become Better At Helping Each Other With Helping Heuristics

A do-it-yourself workshop for teams and organizations to develop the skills they need to ask for help, and to give it effectively



**The
Liberators**

The Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there,

If a team or organization decides to work empirically with Scrum, they will inevitably run into impediments. An "impediment" is any problem that blocks the developers of a Scrum team from achieving the Sprint Goal and is outside their control or ability to resolve on their own.

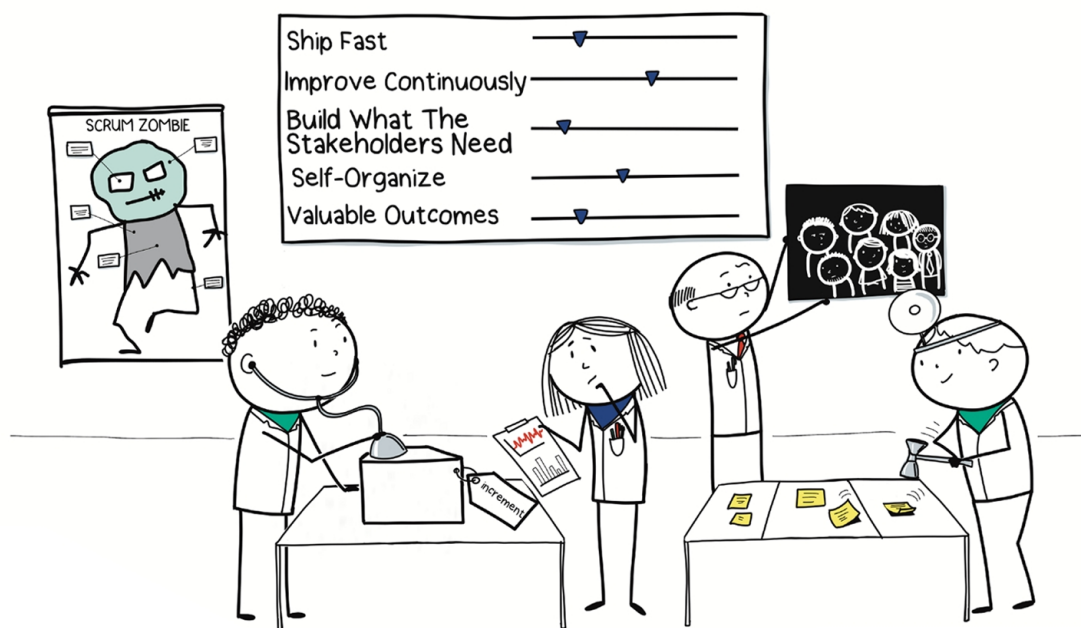
So it's only natural that people and teams will frequently need help with those impediments. But asking for help, and giving it effectively, isn't easy. It takes skill to both clearly explain what the challenge is, and for others to understand it and then offer useful recommendations.

We designed this workshop specifically to help your team, and those around them, develop the essential skills of asking for and giving help. It's a great way to build a learning organization and to improve how to collaborate with others.

Give this string a try, and let us know the results.

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Created by Thea Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Flow

Step 1: Opening

 3 min

Step 2: Identify A Personal Challenge With "Mad Tea"

  10 min

Step 3: Learn How To Ask For, And Give Help With "Helping Heuristics"

  40 min

Step 4: Debrief With "What, So What, Now What"

  35 min

Step 5: Closing

 2 min

Total duration

 90 min

Difficulty / Effort

Required Skill



This string is easy to facilitate and guaranteed to result in at least some compelling insights – and get help on some actual challenges.

Impact On Survival



This workshop helps people in your organization build the skills they need to more effectively ask for, and give help.



How To Prepare



Group Size

This string of Liberating Structures is feasible from 4 participants and onward. You can also run parallel sessions of this string at the same time, involving many more Scrum teams and many more stakeholders.

Intended Audience

This workshop can be done with any configuration of participants, really. We've done it with different Scrum teams at the same time, also including people from the supporting organization. But you can also do it with a single team, with communities of practice in your organization – like developers, designers, Scrum Masters, Product Owners, and so on.

Virtual Delivery

Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

Preparation

- Create a shared space (on a wall, the floor, or virtually) where you can collect insights from the various rounds.
- Prepare slides or supporting materials for the various rounds and their invitations.

Resources

- Myth: [The Scrum Master Must Resolve Every Problem](#)
- Podcast: [Liberating Structures Are Skills To Be Learned By Users, Not Facilitators](#)
- Blogpost: [Practice Progressive Methods For Giving And Getting Helping With Helping Heuristics](#)
- Blogpost: [Using Liberating Structures To Increase Empathy](#)
- Get a [deck of Liberating Structures Design Cards](#)



Learning How To Help

How can we help each other, effectively? This is one of the challenges that lie at the heart of building learning organizations, where people and teams collaborate to overcome shared and individual challenges. When we think of helping as a skill, it is obvious that most of us have a lot to learn here.

At the same time, the complex nature of product development means that we often need help and that others often ask for it. For example, a nasty bug may pop up that completely befuddles Developers. A Scrum Master may struggle to deal with unpleasant team dynamics. Or a Product Owner may have trouble reaching out to a key group of stakeholders. On a larger scale, several Scrum teams may struggle to agree on a shared Definition of Done, or how to automate their release pipeline effectively.

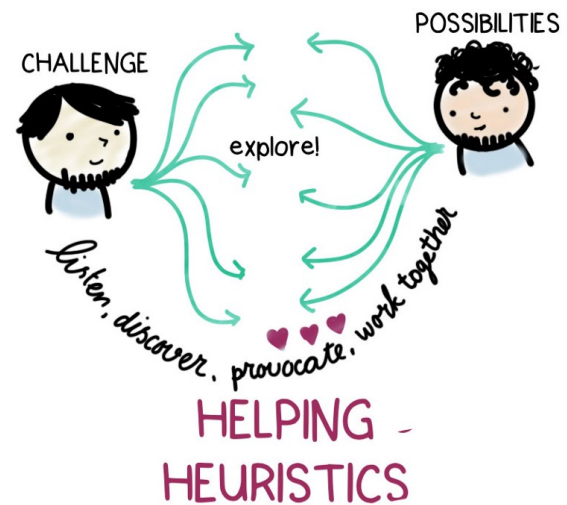
If people don't know how to ask for help or how to give it, or when the quality of help is low and unsatisfying, learning will not occur. And you'll probably remain stuck in Zombie Scrum.

When Is Help Of Low Quality?

It's easy to offer help, but very hard to give it. It's also very difficult to ask for the right kind of help. Just think about times in your recent past where you asked for help and someone gave it. What usually happened? It's entirely likely that people offer well-meaning recommendations right off the bat, without really listening or understanding the problem. It's also possible that you struggled to explain the problem well or were afraid to be fully open to your partner. Either way, it is obvious that our patterns for "Giving Help" and "Getting Help" can use work.

Helping Heuristics

We designed this string of Liberating Structures to help you, your team, and those around them, to more effectively help each other. The beating heart in this string is "[Helping Heuristics](#)". We've found it to be an excellent way to allow groups (of any size) to help each other, but also to learn how to help and ask for help.



Step 1: Opening

Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then explain the purpose and start with the first structure. Superfast!

We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves, or to wait for people to drop in.



Step 2: Identify A Personal Challenge With "Mad Tea"

This workshop works best when everyone, or almost everyone, can bring a (personal) challenge to get help on. That way, everyone has the opportunity to practice asking for help and using the various patterns of Helping Heuristics to give help. We're using "[Mad Tea](#)" for this.

Invitation

1. "What connects me to this group is ..."
2. "The best thing about my job is.."
3. "If I were in charge I would..."
4. "My best source of support is...."
5. "I like to help others by ..."
6. "An annoying challenge I face in my work is that ..."

Steps (In-Person)

- **1 min** Ask people to form two concentric circles, standing at arm's length from each other. Invite people to form pairs with a person standing directly across from them.
- **2 min** Explain that you will be offering short sentences for the participants to complete. The pairs then have 1 minute to complete the sentence with the first thing that comes to mind for them, 30 seconds for each partner.
- **6 min** Offer the invitations in order and give the pairs 1 minute to complete. After one minute, ring a bell or raise your arm to signal that the outer circle moves one person to the right. The inner-circle remains where they are. Then present the next invitation. Repeat until you've gone through all the invitations

Steps (Virtual)

- In the virtual collaboration tool that you're using, ask everyone to open a shared chat window.
- Explain that you will be offering short sentences for the participants to complete. People have 20 seconds to write down the first thing that comes to mind, but submit it only to the chat window on your signal.
- **4 min** Offer the invitations in order. Give participants about 20 seconds to write down the first thing that comes to mind for them. On your sign, everyone hits "enter". Continue with the next invitation until you're done.
- **3 min** Now invite everyone to scroll back through all the responses and notice what strikes them.

Our Findings

- Mad Tea is purposefully quick to energize brains and make connections in the group quickly.
- Encourage people to don't overthink their answers and have them trust their gut-feeling.

Resources

- Blogpost: [Engage Everyone Simultaneously in Generating Questions, Ideas, and Suggestions with 1–2–4–ALL](#)



Step 3: Learn How To Ask For, And Give Help With "Helping Heuristics"



In the previous step, you gave everyone time to think of a personal challenge that they face in their work. In this step, we use Helping Heuristics to explore that challenge in small groups. It is a remarkably powerful Liberating Structures that allow groups to see how different patterns of helping behavior work on a particular challenge and client.

Steps

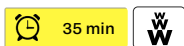
1. **2 min** Explain that the purpose of Helping Heuristics is to progressively give and ask for help, and to explore what is made possible by this progression;
2. If you're doing this in-person, we recommend that you first ask everyone to self-organize into groups of three (some fours are okay if you need to even out) and sit in a small circle. If you're doing this virtually, you can create breakouts after the next step.
3. In three rounds of 12 minutes each, participants rotate between three roles: coach, observer, and client. During each round, the client first shares a personal challenge, after which the coach applies four progressive methods for giving help. In the meantime, the observer notices patterns in the interaction as well as what is made possible by the methods;
4. **3 min** **Pattern 1: Quiet Listening:** The client shares his or her challenge while the coach listens with full attention;
5. **3 min** **Pattern 2: Guided Discovery:** The coach explores the challenge with the client by asking only open-ended questions, without passing judgments or offering his/her own thoughts;
6. **3 min** **Pattern 3: Gentle Provocation:** Now that the coach understands more of the challenge, he or she can now offer advice and gently provoke where they see underlying assumptions, beliefs, or possibilities that the client does not see;
7. **3 min** **Pattern 4: Working Together:** The coach and the client continue their exploration of the challenge and potential solutions by engaging in an open, two-way conversation;
8. Repeat until all participants have had the opportunity to be client, coach, and observer once;

Our Findings

- If you've done Helping Heuristics before with this group, you can also turn the "Observer" into a second "Coach".
- If you don't have the time, you can also do only one or two rounds of Helping Heuristics. Give the small groups time to pick who has the opportunity to act as the client.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- The [article](#) we wrote about Helping Heuristics



Step 4: Debrief With "What, So What, Now What"

Now that participants had the opportunity to share a challenge, and explore how to ask for, and give help, we're going to debrief what that was like. Specifically, we're asking people to reflect on how the four patterns of Helping Heuristics worked for them and others. This often leads to compelling insights about how people in this organization learn, and what can be improved.

Invitation

Round 1: "What have you seen, heard, or observed in yourself and your partners while you received help or offered it through the four patterns of helping heuristics?"

Round 2: "So, what does this mean for how you ask for and give help? What does this suggest about us as a group?"

Round 3: "Now, which pattern would you like to invest in for yourself, and for us as a group, to more effectively help each other?"

Steps

Round 1: Observations

1. **1 min** First individually and in silence, ask people to write down their thoughts on the first invitation. What did they see, hear or observe? Encourage people to remain as factual as possible, taking the perspective of what an outsider would have noticed;
2. **4 min** Ask everyone to form small groups (2–4 people) to share what they noticed. Encourage them to focus on similarities and differences. If you're doing this virtually, move people into breakouts.
3. **4 min** Together, ask each group to share one observation that they feel is most important to their work together. Capture (other) observations on a shared workspace.

Round 2: Conclusions

1. **1 min** First individually and in silence, ask people to write down their thoughts on the second invitation. What conclusions can they draw? What do their observations say about this group?
2. **4 min** Ask everyone to form small groups (2–4 people) to share their conclusions on what seems important. Encourage them to notice patterns. If you're doing this virtually, move people into breakouts.
3. **4 min** Together, ask each group to share one conclusion that they feel is most important. Capture (other) conclusions on a shared workspace.

Round 3: Adaptations



1. **1 min** First individually and in silence, ask people to write down their thoughts on the third invitation. Based on the conclusions from the second round, what makes sense now?
2. **4 min** Ask everyone to form small groups (2–4 people) to share their suggestions for the adaptations that need to be made. Encourage them to notice patterns. If you're doing this virtually, move people into breakouts.
3. **4 min** Together, ask each group to share one adaptation that they feel is most important. Capture (other) adaptations on a shared workspace.

Follow-Up Patterns

You may discover that the group discovers that some patterns are lacking, while they may be very good at others. For example, the group may notice that they struggle with listening, or that they find it difficult to gently provoke. Other Liberating Structures can amplify these patterns, and you can use them in your Scrum events and gatherings to grow those skills together:

- Pattern 1, Quiet Presence, can be amplified with the Liberating Structure "Heard, Seen, Respected"] (<https://www.liberatingstructures.com/19-heard-seen-respected-hsr/>)
- Pattern 2, Guided Discovery, can be amplified with the Liberating Structure ["Appreciative Interviews"](#).
- Pattern 3, Gentle Provocation, can be amplified with the Liberating Structure ["Troika Consulting"](#) or ["Wise Crowds"](#).
- Pattern 4, Working Together, can be amplified with Liberating Structures like ["Improv Prototyping"](#) and ["Discovery & Action Dialogue"](#).

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Create shared understanding with 'What, So What, Now What'](#)

 2 min

Step 5: Closing

If you have the time, do a quick debrief with the group. A simple Liberating Structure for this is [Impromptu Networking](#) ("What did you observe, think or feel while participating in this gathering?"). Draw out some salient patterns from the whole group, but keep it short.

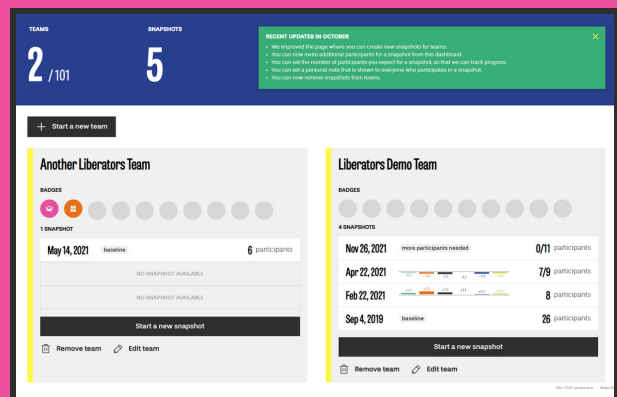
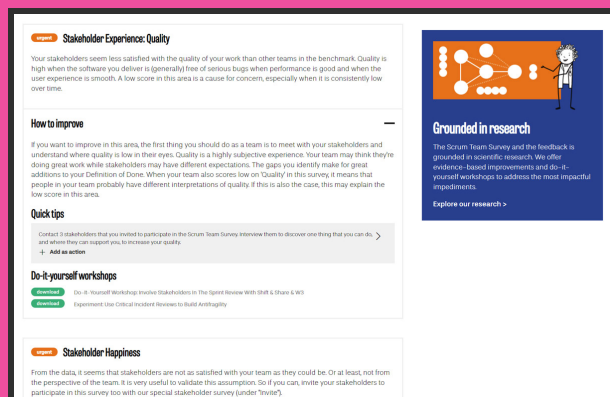
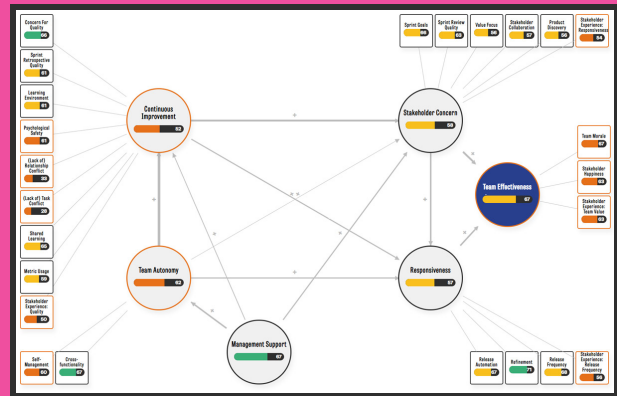
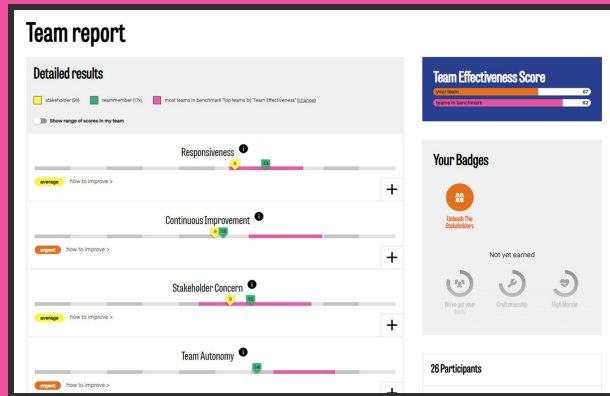
If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

Let's learn and grow, together!



Make Your Scrum Team More Effective

Want to make your Scrum team more effective? We created the Scrum Team Survey to help. Invite members and stakeholders to a detailed questionnaire and diagnose the results together. You receive tons of actionable feedback based on your results, including dozens of quick tips and useful do-it-yourself workshops. You can use the Scrum Team Survey for free with your team. No account or e-mail address is required. You can also subscribe for more advanced features.



	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Analyze the range of scores in your team		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Team Trends		✓
Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 10

<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

info@scrumteamsurvey.org

Unleashing Teams All Over The World

We are The Liberators – Barry Overeem and Christiaan Verwijs. Our mission is to create data-driven products to unleash the superpowers of teams all over the world. We do this together with a growing community of patrons.

Awesome content for awesome teams

We unleash teams with our [blogposts](#), our [podcast](#), our [newsletter](#), our [videos](#), and our frequent [meetups](#). While we offer most of this for free, we also have plenty of premium content in [our webshop](#) for you to explore.

Supported by the community

We are super proud that The Liberators is almost entirely funded by the community. If you appreciate our work too, you can already support us for 12 dollars/year by becoming a [patron](#). In return, you gain free access to premium content, we share our work-in-progress and involve you in creating more awesome content.



Thank you for respecting our work!

We work hard to create high-quality content that puts you in a position to unleash your team. We're sure you appreciate that a lot of our time and money goes into this. At the same time, content like this is our main source of income. It's what pays our bills :)

If you purchased this content, we ask only that you treat our work with respect and don't share it with people outside your team. If you stumbled on it elsewhere without paying for it, and it offers you value, would you consider [supporting us too](#)? You can also check [out our other offerings](#).